

Thrive

Financial Literacy App

Gamified, bite sized money education that turns learning into action for young people

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1. Executive Summary

Most young people reach adulthood without ever being taught how money works. Schools rarely cover budgeting, credit, or investing, and the financial content that fills the gap on social media is often unreliable. Thrive is a gamified, bite sized financial literacy app, built in the spirit of Duolingo, that teaches money skills through short daily lessons, streaks, and rewards.

Where Thrive differs from a pure knowledge app is its learn then do loop: every lesson ends with one small real world action, so knowledge becomes habit. Thrive targets young people roughly ages 16 to 25 who are forming their first money habits, and grows with them from the basics of budgeting through credit, saving, and investing.

Why now

Gen Z is hungry for financial knowledge and already turns to short form finance content, but that content is unvetted and inconsistent. There is room for a trusted, structured, and genuinely engaging app that meets this generation where they already are: on their phones, in small daily doses, with game mechanics that make a historically dry subject stick.

2. Problem Statement

User problem

Young people want to be good with money but were never taught how. They feel anxious and behind, do not know where to start, and distrust both traditional finance and the noise of social media. Existing resources are either boring, such as textbooks and long articles, or unreliable, such as random influencers, and almost none translate knowledge into action.

Market problem

Financial literacy is a large, underserved need with no dominant consumer first brand that young people love the way they love Duolingo. Existing players skew toward distribution through banks and credit unions, or toward young children and their parents, leaving the self directed teen and young adult learner without a product built for them. Whoever earns this generation's trust early owns a durable relationship and several paths to revenue.

3. User Personas

Persona	Snapshot	Primary pain point
The Anxious Beginner (Maya, 18)	Just got her first job and debit card and feels overwhelmed.	Does not know where to start and is afraid of making mistakes.
The FinTok Curious (Devin, 21)	Watches money videos but cannot tell good advice from bad.	Information overload with no structure or trusted source.
The Ambitious Student (Aaliyah, 20)	Wants to invest and start building wealth early.	Ready for more than basics, but most resources stop at budgeting.
The Reluctant Learner (Marcus, 16)	Knows he should learn about money but finds it boring.	Needs it to feel like a game, not like homework.

4. Goals and Success Metrics

Qualitative goals

- Make money education genuinely engaging rather than a chore.
- Build real confidence and habits, not just knowledge.
- Become the trusted first money app for a generation of young people.

Quantitative targets

Metric	Baseline	Target	Measurement
Day 7 retention	New product	35%	Product analytics
Lessons completed per active user weekly	New product	4	Product analytics
Action step completion rate	New product	40%	Feature telemetry
Self reported confidence lift	Baseline	+20 points	In app survey
Monthly active users at 12 months	0	100K	Product analytics

- **North Star metric:** weekly active learners completing at least one money action.

5. Scope

In scope (MVP)

- A gamified lesson player with XP, daily streaks, and a lives mechanic.
- A structured beginner track covering budgeting, banking, credit basics, and saving.
- The learn then do action step after each lesson.
- Daily reminder notifications and a basic progress profile.
- Groundwork for a freemium model.

Out of scope (for MVP)

- Live trading, brokerage, or connecting real bank accounts.
- Personalized financial advice that requires a licensed advisor.

- The advanced investing and wealth building track (planned for phase two).
- Community and social features (planned for phase two).
- Distribution through schools and financial institutions (later phase).

6. Functional Requirements

ID	Requirement	Priority
FR1	Lesson player delivers short, interactive lessons with quizzes and instant feedback.	Must Have
FR2	Gamification with XP, daily streaks, and a lives mechanic.	Must Have
FR3	A structured beginner curriculum organized into units and skills.	Must Have
FR4	Each lesson ends with one concrete real world action step the user can mark complete.	Must Have
FR5	Daily reminder notifications to protect streaks.	Must Have
FR6	A progress profile showing streak, completed skills, and confidence growth.	Should Have
FR7	A placement check so users can skip basics they already know.	Should Have
FR8	A freemium structure with core lessons free and premium unlocks.	Should Have
FR9	Advanced tracks covering investing, taxes, credit, and wealth building (phase two).	Nice to Have
FR10	A social layer with friends, leaderboards, and shared challenges (phase two).	Nice to Have
FR11	Expert and creator authored content modules.	Nice to Have

7. Non Functional Requirements

- **Accuracy and trust:** all content is reviewed by qualified financial educators, cites reputable sources, never presents opinion as fact, and is clearly framed as education rather than personalized advice.
- **Accessibility:** meets WCAG AA, uses plain language at an approachable reading level, and runs on lower end devices.
- **Performance:** lessons load instantly and run smoothly on a typical mobile connection, with offline caching where possible.
- **Privacy and safety:** minimal data collection, strong protections for users under 18, and compliance with applicable regional privacy law.
- **Engagement integrity:** gamification motivates learning without manipulative dark patterns.

8. Risks and Assumptions

Risks

- **Fading engagement:** novelty can wear off. Mitigate with fresh content, streak mechanics, and real world relevance.
- **Accuracy and liability:** teaching finance carries real risk. Mitigate with expert review and clear disclaimers.

- **Crowded space:** several gamified finance apps exist. Differentiate on the action loop, consumer first design, and trust.
- **Monetization:** a young, price sensitive audience is hard to monetize. Freemium can work but typically requires scale.

Assumptions

- Young people will engage with money education if it feels like a game.
- The learn then do loop drives real behavior change and differentiates Thrive.
- A consumer first brand can win where business to business players have not.
- Freemium plus later revenue paths are viable once the app reaches scale.

9. Proposed Timeline

Phase	Focus	Duration
Discovery and curriculum	User research and beginner curriculum design with an educator.	5 weeks
Design and prototype	Lesson player UX, gamification, and the action loop.	5 weeks
Build MVP	Lesson engine, gamification, beginner track, and reminders.	10 weeks
Closed beta	Test with a student cohort and measure retention and confidence.	5 weeks
Public launch (v1)	App store launch with the beginner track and freemium.	3 weeks

10. Open Questions

- What is the precise launch audience: high schoolers, college students, or both?
- Should investing content ship in the MVP or wait for phase two?
- What is the right monetization model and timing: freemium, sponsorships, or both?
- How do we source and maintain accurate, current content at scale?
- Do we lead consumer first, or pursue a school and organization channel in parallel?
- How do we handle users under 18 with respect to privacy and parental consent?

11. Appendix

- **Inspiration:** Duolingo's engagement model of streaks, XP, and bite sized daily lessons.
- **Differentiators:** the learn then do action loop, consumer first design, and growth from basics to wealth building.
- **Context:** the rise of short form finance content and the persistent financial literacy gap among young people.
- **Glossary:** streak, XP, freemium, action step, North Star metric.
- **Founder note:** this concept aligns with hands on financial literacy education work and a long standing interest in personal finance.